FINAL PROJECT

THEORETICAL CONCEPT

- Online Master Model -



Design and implemented by: UNIVERSITÀ DI TORINO

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1. TITLE: Leveraging ICT to Empower Poor Communities and Unemployed Youth in Jordan through the Gig Economy

2. FIELD: ICT Development, Economic Empowerment, Poverty Reduction and Digital Inclusion.

3. FULL NAME: Ibrahim Moh'd Saleh Al-Malkawi/ Amman Jordan

4. ABSTRACT

This research investigates how ICT can address some of the socio-economic challenges in Jordan, in practical among poor communities and unemployed youth. The gig economy is the focus of this study in trying to understand the potential of digital tools to create alternatives income sources for poor communities and unemployed youth. For the research I have used a mix-method approach, this study will employ thematic analysis to identify strategies that could further enhance the accessibility, better skill development, and sustainability of Jordan's gig economy. The findings bring to light the transformative potential of ICTs in bridging the digital divide, econ-inclusion, and socio-economic development.

5. INTRODUCTION AND MAIN QUESTIONS

The digital divide in Jordan affects poor communities and jobless young people more than others. Even though there have been improvements in ICT infrastructure, access and digital skills are not equal, especially in rural and refugee areas. This research looks at how ICT can help marginalized groups by providing access to the gig economy, which offers flexible and different job opportunities.
Research Questions:

1. What is the role of ICTs in overcoming the digital divide for poor communities' digital inclusion in Jordan?
2. What is the gig economy current states in Jordan and how it can serve as an alternative income source among poor communities and unemployed youth?
3. What are the socioeconomic challenges/ barriers poor communities and unemployed youth are facing?
4. What strategies can be implemented to ensure that gig economy work is sustainable and provides fair compensation to youth in Jordan?

6. OBJECTIVES

- To investigate how can ICT support the efforts to reduce the barriers for poor communities and unemployed youth to enable them to participate in the gig economy.

- To explore the current gig economy status in Jordan, it's potential and opportunities to generate income for poor communities and unemployed youth.
- To discuss ICT strategies through which gig economy can be sustainable for poor communities and unemployed youth.
- To offer actionable insights into leveraging ICT for NGOs, governments, and platforms to create inclusive digital job opportunities.

7. METHODOLOGY AND RESEARCH METHODS

The research objectives are precise upon clear focuses that help give a detailed view of how ICTs could enable economic empowerment for unemployed poor youth in Jordan. In this direction, these objectives take the research further in the direction of findings of actionable insights, assessment of the role of technology, and challenges and opportunities as posed by the gig economy.
This study is based on a conceptual framework emphasizing the role of ICT in combating disparities in socioeconomic status. The current research is underpinned by the principles of digital inclusion, equity, and empowerment; these principles come under Jordan's national priorities to attain economic growth through ICT.
The design of the research employed a mixed approach. Data sources for the literature review were gathered from scientific journals, international organizations' reports, and governmental reports. The research also collected data from economic development experts at the government, and international and national organizations through Key Informative Interviews (KIIs). NVivo was used for content analysis.

8. DISCUSSION OF THE IMPLICATION OF THE MASTER PROGRAMME

The project is using learning and tools studied during the Master and in particular:

- Digital inclusion theories to address accessibility.
- Training and upskilling programs to bridge the digital divide.
- Financial inclusion and poverty reduction.
- Practice of thematic analysis and coding using NVivo.
- Utilization of ICT tools, therefore, gig platforms, in the Jordanian context. These links demonstrate the potential for ICT to be used for social good in the development sector.

9. DISCUSSION OF THE FINAL RESULT/PRODUCT/FINDINGS AND ANALYSIS

The research findings indicate that with ICT and through the gig economy, have relatively high potentials for transformative contributions to address the socio-economic challenges of Jordan's marginal groups. Some ICT-related initiatives, like DiSkills and the YTJ project, showed the potential to reduce the digital divide and foster greater economic inclusion. These range from digital skills enhancement programs to access to technology initiatives that help poor communities and unemployed youth join the emerging digital economy. Yet, there are still so many barriers to this happening on a scale, or in a truly sustainable way.

One of the main challenges identified is the unequal distribution of institutional infrastructure of digital resources, how high costs of digital devices and Internet access in rural and poor communities, and further the digital divide in engaging in opportunities using ICTs. While government and NGOs have been leading these processes to address such inequity, there is still a need for further focused investments in

more available and inexpensive digital equipment with reliable Internet access. Without this base level of resources, initiatives for better digital inclusion are piecemeal and insufficient.

The gig economy in Jordan can prove to be one potential pathway to generate income, offering a prospect of flexible employments in various fields. platforms like Khamsat and Mostaql, operating with Arabic language services, reduce the barrier of language and clearly outline opportunities for youths possessing basic digital skills. At the same time, however, the lack of a regulatory framework on gig work is a major challenge. Gig workers face precariousness, in particular precarious income, lack of social protection, and scarcity of procedures for dispute resolution. This present regulatory gap, therefore, is really discouraging long-term participation and sustaining financial insecurity amongst gig economy workers.

Culture and social norms further compounded these challenges. For example, gendered constraints include caregiving responsibilities and societal expectations that inhibit women's participation in gig work. Respondents emphasized that what is required is the design of gender-sensitive programs which can target such binding constraints to achieve broader inclusive participation in the digital economy. This is supported by existing literature, which emphasizes holistic approaches toward digital inclusion, taking into consideration cultural and social dynamics.

Skills development emerged as a factor in participation in the gig economy. While DigiSkills is a very good example for basic digital literacy training, there is a need to further develop advanced skills among respondents. Advanced competencies specializing in coding, graphic designing, and digital marketing are being asked in many gig economy jobs, which are not available to marginalized groups. The respondents said that tiered training models, in which technical skills are built up incrementally, would better prepare participants for transitioning from low-skilled to higher-skilled gig work. This model improves the employability of a person but also contributes toward the gig economy's overall sustainability as an employment-generating sector.

Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs) were identified as a key strategy to overcome these challenges. Such cooperation among government agencies, NGOs, and other stakeholders in the private sector will lead to increased digital infrastructure, expanded access to training programs, and the creation of supportive ecosystems for gig work. Indeed, government-backed financial incentives to businesses hiring from underserved regions epitomize the role played by such partnerships in the pursuit of inclusive economic growth. Additionally, integration with formal education on digital skills training creates a pipeline of digitally literate youth who are ready to engage in the gig economy.

In conclusion, this research highlights the dual narrative of opportunity and challenge within Jordan's ICT and gig economy landscape. While ICT and gig platforms can provide pathways toward economic inclusion, the exploitation of their full potential needs to overcome systemic barriers such as the digital divide, skill gaps, and regulatory deficiencies. Surmounting these barriers will require multidimensional interventions in the form of policy reforms, targeted skill development, and strategic partnerships. Addressing these challenges will enable Jordan to unlock the transformative potential of ICT and the gig economy in empowering its marginalized populations and driving inclusive socio-economic development.

10. CONCLUSIONS

This study brings out immense potentiality with which the gig economy and ICT can contribute to addressing some of the major socioeconomic challenges of marginalized populations in Jordan. ICT interventions, such as the DigiSkills and Youth, Technology, and Jobs project, had been leading from the

front to bridge the digital divide for economic inclusion by expanding access to digital means and skill sets. Yet, their impact is obviously constrained by the high cost of technologies, inadequate infrastructure, and other socio-cultural barriers.

The gig economy offers flexible work options, largely through the localized platforms Khamsat and Mostaql. Being without the protective policy of regulations, workers are most susceptible to exposure to exploitation, economic insecurity, and social exclusion. Further, the cultural and economic issues affecting women and rural youth also raise the necessity of designing policies that are sensitive and inclusive.

Addressing these issues requires a coordinated approach between government, NGOs, and the private sector. Compensation regulations, social protection, and long-term sustainability for workers in the gig economy need reform. Increased investment in digital infrastructure and access to technology at affordable prices holds the key to better participation, especially in areas that have been left behind.

Skill development is central to the success of these initiatives his would mean tiered training programs that help move workers from a basic digital literacy level to higher-end skills-building involvement in gainful gig work. Thirdly, partnerships between the public and private sectors can enhance such initiatives to ensure flexibility while being concurrent with market demand.

While the transformative potentials exist both in ICT and the gig economy, concrete success stories from Jordan really depend on how systemic barriers are addressed with specific interventions. An inclusive enabling digital ecosystem can help Jordan in empowering the marginalized, reducing unemployment, and furthering the sustainable socio-economic development of the nation.

11. APPENDIX: MATERIALS & PROTOTYPES

Please insert below any other information, document, prototype, url link, that you think would be important for the Commission to read or have a look at, such as: survey data, data visualization, technological prototype, mockup, etc.. You may consider submitting them also as Appendix.

Final Report Link: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1x5R4kYq3LDb3ieGjWZHorENO-GjP0xIi/view?usp=sharing
This link provides access to the full report, which includes detailed findings, analysis, and recommendations.